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National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) - Role of NDRF in Disaster Management for UPSC!

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The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) was constituted by the Government of India in compliance with the [Disaster Management Act, 2005](#), as a specialized force that acts responsibly for a major disaster. Since the Force's inception in 2006, it has been instrumental in managing the nation's calamities and raising awareness for Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR).

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) is one of the important topics for the UPSC IAS exam. It is a part of the Disaster Management subject in the Mains [General Studies Paper-III syllabus](#) and General Studies Paper-1 of the [UPSC Prelims Syllabus](#).

In this article, we shall study the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), its roles and responses, and its significance. We will also talk about Disaster Management (Amendment) Bill, 2024 for the UPSC exam.

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What Is NDRF (National Disaster Response Force)?

In India, there were numerous natural disasters between 1990 and 2004. The Disaster Management Act was passed as a result on December 26, 2005. The [National Disaster Management Authority \(NDMA\)](#) was established in accordance with this act to develop plans, strategies, and guidelines for disaster management.

On January 19, 2006, the NDMA established the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) as the nation's top rescue response organization. "Aapada Seva Sadaiv Sarvatra" is their motto. It denotes a consistent disaster response service in all situations. Since its founding, the nation has celebrated the NDRF Raising Day annually. Shri Atul Karwal, IPS is the chairman of NDRF.

About NDRF

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) specializes in quick, adequate, and effective responses to natural and man-made calamities.

Feature	Details
Full Name	National Disaster Response Force (NDRF)
Established Under	Disaster Management Act, 2005
Operational Since	2006
Nodal Ministry	Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Government of India
Headquarters	New Delhi, India
Controlling Authority	National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA)



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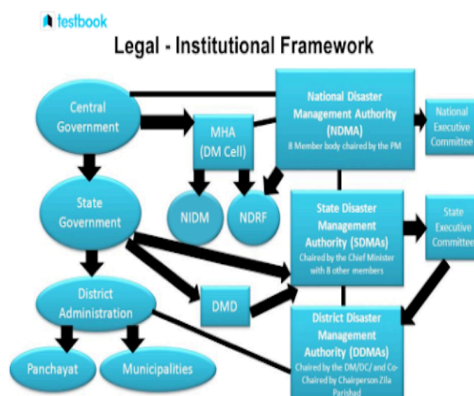




Objective	To provide a specialized response to natural and man-made disasters including earthquakes, floods, cyclones, industrial accidents, and CBRN (Chemical, Biological, Radiological, Nuclear) emergencies.
Composition	- Comprises 12 battalions drawn from various paramilitary forces such as BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP, and SSB. - Each battalion has around 1,149 personnel.
Headquarters & Regional Distribution	- HQ: New Delhi. - Regional bases in Guwahati, Kolkata, Mundali (Odisha), Arakkonam (Tamil Nadu), Pune, Gandhinagar, Bathinda, Ghaziabad, Varanasi, Vijayawada, Patna, and Bengaluru to ensure quick response across the country.
Training & Specialization	- Trained in search and rescue, medical first response, collapsed structure rescue, flood rescue, and CBRN emergencies. - Personnel also conduct community awareness and mock drills for disaster preparedness.
Motto	"Saving Lives and Beyond"
Functions	- Rapid response to natural and man-made disasters. - Capacity building and community awareness. - Coordination with State Disaster Response Forces (SDRFs) and local authorities.
Significant Operations	- 2013 Uttarakhand floods rescue. - 2018 Kerala floods. - 2015 Nepal earthquake assistance. - 2020 Cyclone Amphan and COVID-19 operations.
Recent Development	NDRF has integrated technology-based disaster management tools, including drones and GIS systems, for rapid response.

Composition of NDRF

- Currently, NDRF India is a force of 15 battalions staffed by personnel from the Assam Rifles, the Border Security Force (BSF), Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) and the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB).
- Each battalion has an overall strength of 1149, comprising 18 self-contained specialized search and rescue teams with 45 members, including dog squads, engineers, technicians, and electricians.
- Depending on the nation's vulnerability profile and shortening the response time for their deployment to disaster areas, these NDRF battalions are spread out over 16 distinct locations all through the nation.



NDRF Training

The Center has established a National Institute of Excellence for Search and Rescue in Nagpur, as training is considered to be the most essential aspect of an efficient force.

The employees go through a nine-week period of rigorous training.

- Basic First Respondent Course (BFRC)
- Medical First Respondent Course (MERC) - educates personnel with first aid skills to assist victims post-rescue.



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Disaster Management Act, 2005

- The UN's adoption of the Yokohama Strategic Plan (1994) and the Hyogo Framework for Action (2005) were the major global disaster response and preparedness developments that took place in the 90s and the decade that followed.
- India saw some of its worst natural disasters during that time, including the Orissa Super Cyclone (1999), the Gujarat Earthquake (2001), and the Indian Ocean Tsunami (2004).
- This series of events and the global context mandated the requirement of a comprehensive disaster management plan. This resulted in the Disaster Management Act being passed on December 26th, 2005.

NDRF Raising Day

- The NDRF Raising Day honors the personnel's selfless commitment.
- It's a day to express gratitude to the military for its immeasurable commitment to national security during disaster relief.
- Also, the purpose of the day is to increase public awareness of the NDRF personnel services.






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Disaster Management (Amendment) Bill, 2024

The Disaster Management Act, 2005 established the institutional framework for disaster preparedness, mitigation, and response in India. It created key bodies such as the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), State Disaster Management Authorities (SDMAs), and the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF).

With the rise in climate-related disasters, urban risks, and the need for stronger local governance, the Government of India introduced the Disaster Management (Amendment) Bill, 2024 on 1 August 2024. The aim is to modernize the existing Act by strengthening institutional mechanisms, integrating urban disaster resilience, and enhancing coordination across central, state, and local levels.







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State Disaster Response Forces (SDRFs):

The Bill provides for the creation of statutory State Disaster Response Forces, similar to the NDRF, to strengthen disaster response capacity at the state level.

•

Statutory Status for Committees:

Grants legal status to the National Crisis Management Committee (NCMC) and the High-Level Committee (HLC), institutionalizing their roles in national disaster coordination and relief allocation.

•

Disaster Database and Preparedness Audit:

Mandates the creation of comprehensive national and state-level disaster databases, periodic preparedness audits, and post-disaster reviews to improve long-term planning and accountability.

•

Enhanced Role of NDMA and SDMA:

Authorizes NDMA and SDMA to directly prepare disaster management plans instead of relying solely on executive committees, ensuring stronger leadership in preparedness and mitigation.

•

New Section 60A – Directive Powers and Penalties: Introduces provisions enabling Central and State Governments to issue binding directions for disaster

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- Delivering a prompt and efficient response to emergencies and disasters.
- Performing rescue operations
- Extending humanitarian aid in times of crisis.
- Working in collaboration with other institutions to provide relief and rehabilitation.
- Providing operational-level training to State Response Forces (Police, Civil Defense, and Home Guards)
- Organizing Community Capacity Building Programs and campaigns to raise public awareness.
- Engaging in effective training exercises and mock drills.

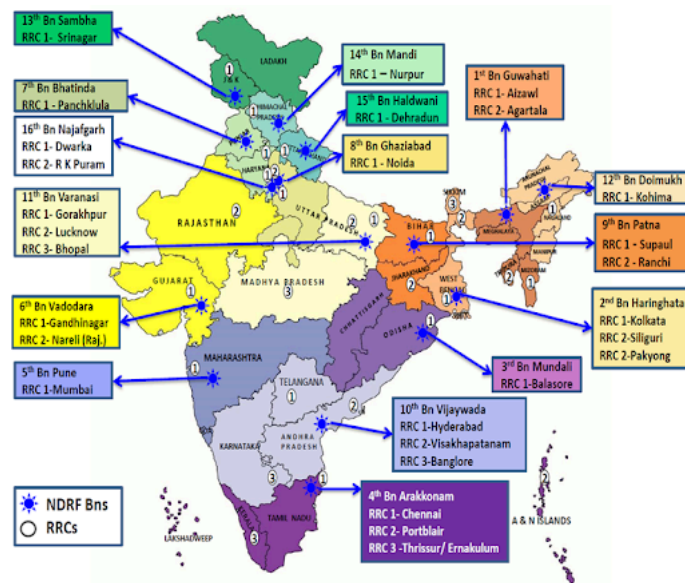
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Deployment of NDRF in India

With the aim of speeding up the response time for the deployment of the NDRF battalions to the disaster sites, on the basis of the nation's vulnerability profile, these battalions are distributed among 16 different locations in the country. During the planning stage or in the event of an unforeseen disaster, the NDMA will deploy the NDRF proactively in collaboration with state authorities.



Source: NDRF

e Response of NDRF to some Recent Disaster

Since its establishment, the NDRF has persisted in winning the hearts of millions of fellow citizens by tackling challenges with skill and compassion.

Syria and Turkey Earthquake, February 2023

In Turkey and Syria, the severe earthquake that struck on February 6, 2023 caused significant loss of life and property. Soon after the earthquake hit Turkey, India responded with disaster relief materials and forces. It declared "Operation Dost" and deployed a team from the Indian Army to establish 60 Para Field Hospitals and NDRF to provide relief and humanitarian assistance to the quake-hit nation. For the first time, female rescuers were sent to conduct rescue efforts in a foreign nation. The NDRF teams were initially stationed in the worst-affected neighborhoods of Gaziantep, 23 kilometers from the epicenter. The NDRF teams worked day and night, spending long hours cutting through debris to save lives. They used drones to locate people who were buried in the rubble and to provide food, medicine, and other supplies.

Recent Response Operations of NDRF

Year	Operation / Disaster	Location / Country	Key Details
2025	Flash Floods & Landslides	Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Jammu & Kashmir	NDRF teams deployed for large-scale rescue and evacuation; coordinated with SDRF and local administration.
2025	Flood Operations	Maharashtra, Punjab, Gujarat	Swift rescue and relief during monsoon floods; thousands of people evacuated safely.



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2024	Flood & Landslide Operations	Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh	Rapid deployment in flood-affected and landslide-prone regions; coordination with state forces.
2023	Operation Dost	Turkey and Syria	International humanitarian mission for earthquake relief; included search, rescue, and medical aid.
2023	Cyclone Biparjoy	Gujarat, Maharashtra	Conducted preventive evacuation and post-cyclone rescue.
2023	Monsoon Flood Operations	Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh	Carried out flood relief, evacuation, and health support missions.
2022	Assam Floods	Assam	100+ NDRF teams deployed for rescue and relief; large-scale evacuation and medical assistance.
2022	Amarnath Flash Floods	Jammu & Kashmir	Major rescue and recovery operation after a cloudburst near the Amarnath Cave Shrine.
2022	Maharashtra Landslides	Konkan Region	Rescued trapped residents, provided immediate relief, and cleared debris.
2021	Glacial Outburst Flood	Chamoli, Uttarakhand	Rescue and recovery after glacier burst in Rishiganga valley; operation in high-altitude terrain.
2021	Cyclone Yaas	Odisha, West Bengal	Massive evacuation and relief drive before and after cyclone landfall.
2021	COVID-19 Support Operations	Pan-India	Assisted in disinfection, logistics, and emergency management across states.
2020	Gas Leak (LG Polymers)	Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh	Industrial disaster response; evacuation and containment of toxic gas leakage.
2020	Cyclone Amphan	West Bengal, Odisha	One of the largest NDRF operations; over 40 lakh people evacuated.
2020	Flood Operations	Bihar, Assam	Search, rescue, and flood-relief distribution in affected districts.
2019	Monsoon Floods	Bihar, Maharashtra, Assam, Karnataka	NDRF deployed boats and relief teams; extensive flood rescue missions.
2019	Cyclone Fani	Odisha, Andhra Pradesh	Conducted large-scale pre-disaster evacuation and post-disaster rehabilitation.
2018	Kerala Floods	Kerala	Historic operation with 58 NDRF teams; over 70,000 people rescued and rehabilitated.
2018	Cyclone Gaja	Tamil Nadu, Puducherry	Rapid relief and restoration in cyclone-hit coastal districts.



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2015	Operation Maitri	Nepal	International earthquake relief mission; NDRF rescued victims and provided medical care.
2015	Chennai Floods	Tamil Nadu	Urban rescue and evacuation operations amid severe city flooding.

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Contribution Of NDRF to International Disasters

NDRF India has been effective in performing rescue operations and saving lives on a global scale.

- Syria and Turkey Earthquake, February 2023: A severe earthquake hit Turkey on February 6th, 2023 causing significant loss of life and property. India sent NDRF personnel for carrying out rescue operations under "Operation Dost".
- Nepal Earthquake, April 2015: Nepal was struck by a catastrophic earthquake on April 25, 2015. More than 700 rescuers from 16 USAR teams, along with 18 USAR-trained dogs, were sent out by NDRF.
- Japan Triple Disaster, March 2011: In 2011, Japan was struck by an earthquake, followed by a Tsunami and a nuclear meltdown. India sent one NDRF team to the country. Together with the other belongings, the team also found and handed over cash worth 50 million yen. The Japanese government sent a letter of commendation to the Indian embassy as a way of recognizing the efforts of the Indian NDRF team.

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NDRF Members

1. National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA)
2. National Executive Committee (NEC)
3. National Disaster Response Coordination Centre (NDRCC)
4. State Emergency Operation Centres (SEOCs)
5. District Emergency Operation Centres (DEOOCs)
6. Control Rooms at National and State Capitals

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Functional Parameters of NDRF

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) seeks to create a safer and more disaster-resilient India through the development of a comprehensive, proactive, technology-driven strategy for disaster management. This goal emphasizes prevention, mitigation, and preparedness to ensure a swift and efficient response during disasters. The overarching national vision aims to instill a culture of readiness among all involved parties.

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) has played a pivotal role in realizing this vision by conducting highly skilled rescue and relief operations, offering extensive training and retraining programs, conducting familiarization exercises within the respective NDRF Battalion areas, and organizing mock drills and joint exercises in collaboration with various stakeholders.

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National Disaster Response Force: Pros & Cons

The National Disaster Response Force has the following merits and shortcomings:

Pros Of NDRF

The following are the merits of NDRF:

- The NDRF provides well-trained and organized personnel for operations related to disaster response in India.
- The rescue and relief efforts carried out during natural and man-made disasters are the responsibility of the NDRF.
- The NDRF is a specialized force with state-of-the-art equipment to address emergency situations.






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- Sometimes its equipment and training programs fall short of expectations. This became notably obvious during the 2005 earthquake in Kashmir.
- There have been allegations of corruption within the Force.

Despite these inadequacies, the NDRF remains India's biggest hope for disaster response.

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State Disaster Response Force (SDRF)

- The State Governments must establish their own SDRF in accordance with the National Policy on Disaster Management 2009 in order to respond to disasters swiftly.
- The SDRF teams are in 24 States and UTs. These SDRFs are strategically positioned in areas that are convenient for their quick deployment at disaster sites and are connected to the airport, railheads, and roadways.
- The states can also use the SDRF personnel for programs aimed at community capacity building and raising awareness of the public.

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UPSC Previous Year Questions on the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF)

Q 1 Discuss the recent measures initiated in disaster management by the Government of India departing from the earlier reactive approach. (UPSC 2020)

Q 2 Disaster preparedness is the first step in any disaster management process. Explain how hazard zonation mapping will help disaster mitigation in the case of landslides. (UPSC 2019)

Q 3 Describe various measures taken in India for Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR) before and after signing 'Sendai Framework for DRR (2015-2030)'. How is this framework different from 'Hyogo Framework for Action, 2005'? (UPSC 2018)

Q 4 How important is vulnerability and risk assessment for pre-disaster management? As an administrator, what are key areas that you would focus on in a Disaster Management System? (UPSC 2013)

With its remarkable performance during many disasters, such as drowning instances, building collapses, landslides, devastating floods, and cyclones, NDRF has demonstrated its effectiveness. By giving thousands of individuals in need rapid aid and medical attention, NDRF teams also help the local government.

The Indian government also makes enormous efforts to improve disaster preparedness through global cooperation. With nations like Tajikistan, Mongolia, Bangladesh, Italy, Japan, SCO countries, Germany, SAARC countries, Russia, Switzerland, and others, India has various Memorandums of Understanding in the field of disaster management.

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National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) FAQs

How many NDRF battalions are there in India?

Who founded NDRF?

What is the role of the National Disaster Response Force?

What forces are involved in the NDRF?

Who controls the National Disaster Response Force?

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